

4 The repertoire heritage

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Introduction

The indispensable bibliographical index *150 Years of Music for Saxophone* catalogues ‘more than 12,000 works of “classical music” for saxophone, 1844–1994. Not included are the 3,000 symphonic or operatic works in which one or several saxophones appear in the orchestration.’¹ The index lists music from dozens of countries by composers of all levels of recognition and of widely diverse aesthetic approaches. These men and women have written concertos for saxophone with band and with orchestra, sonatas for saxophone and piano, unaccompanied pieces, saxophone ensembles of various sizes, and works for saxophone in unusual combination with instruments such as voice, percussion, organ, tape and synthesizer.

The great majority of these works were written for the alto saxophone; only in the first and the most recent decades of the instrument’s existence have composers given serious consideration to the other members of the family. This chapter will attempt to trace the growth of the saxophone literature, to identify influential compositions, and to create a sense of the heritage of the performing repertoire.

Much of the core of the saxophone repertoire dates from the 1930s and provides a striking parallel with that of the clarinet. Mozart’s clarinet Concerto, K.622, written in 1790, is the first masterpiece for the clarinet, an instrument created around 1700.² The saxophone first appeared around 1840; Ibert’s *Concertino da Camera* was written some ninety years later in 1935, and is a comparable landmark in the history of the saxophone literature. Each composition has important predecessors, but the saxophone repertoire had an important advantage: Adolphe Sax.

The saxophone repertoire to 1900

Adolphe Sax realised that repertoire must exist in order for his newly created instruments to survive. To this end he owned and operated a publishing house in Paris from the late 1850s until the bankruptcy proceedings of the late 1870s. Sax published almost 200 compositions for his instruments, including at least thirty-five for various saxophones and piano.

Monsieur Colblain



FANTAISIE

POUR

Saxophone Soprano Si^b

avec accompagnement de Piano

J.B. SINGELÉE

Exécuté au concours du Conservatoire,

1863.

Op. 89.

Prix: 6'

PARIS, en Vente à la Manufacture de M^r Ad^r SAX,

Facteur Breveté de la Maison Impériale de l'Empereur.

50. Rue St. Georges.

Fig. 4.1 Cover of *Fantaisie* for soprano saxophone by J. B. Singelée, published by Adolphe Sax in 1863

Seven composers supplied music for saxophone and piano, including famous cornetist Joseph Arban, renowned flautist Jules Demersseman, clarinet virtuoso Hyacinthe Klosé and – most prolifically – Jean Baptiste Singelée. A large number of their compositions were *solos de concours* used by the Paris Conservatoire for their annual examinations. The majority of the works are harmonically and structurally conservative; most often an increasingly virtuosic set of variations or a *fantaisie* follows a brief piano introduction. Many of the compositions are solidly constructed and were intended to ensure that the saxophone – soprano, alto, tenor and baritone – would have both a small but important body of literature and the performers to present it.

This legacy of Sax remains little known. Several works by the composers in Sax's catalogue have been recommended as worthy of performance today: *Solo sur la Tyrolienne* by Leon Chic; Demersseman's *Premier solo, andante et bolero*; Jean-Nicholas Savari's *Fantaisie sur des motifs du Freyschutz*, and four works by Singelée – the *Fantaisie*, Op. 89, the *6e solo de concert*, Op. 92, the *7e solo de concert*, Op. 93, and the *Fantaisie*, Op. 102. Demersseman's *Premier solo* and Singelée's *6e solo de concert* are for tenor saxophone; Singelée's *7e solo de concert* is for baritone and his two *Fantaisies* are for soprano. As Bruce Ronkin states, 'Many performers feel that nineteenth-century music is accepted by a wider audience than more contemporary works. Perhaps by adding the Sax publications to the saxophonist's recital repertoire, a broader audience for saxophone concerts might be found, thus enhancing the instrument's acceptance in classical music circles.'³

To World War I

No composer of international stature wrote solo works for the saxophone in the last half of the nineteenth century. But, of course, almost no internationally regarded composer other than Brahms contributed to any other portion of the woodwind literature during that period.

Claude Debussy was one of the earliest important composers to write for the saxophone and is probably the most famous musician ever to have written for the instrument. His association with the Bostonian Elise Boyer

Hall is mentioned in [chapter 3](#). The *Rhapsodie Mauresque for Orchestra and Principal Saxophone* may fail to demonstrate the full capabilities of the saxophone, but does demonstrate the unique colours and qualities of Debussy's music. Comprised of two principal sections, the work has easily recognisable themes that are treated in a free, fantasia-like manner; the vivid Spanish rhythms reflect the original title.

In addition to Debussy's score, Hall commissioned works by composers such as André Caplet, Philippe Gaubert, Charles Martin Loeffler, Georges Longy and Florent Schmitt (see Appendix 1). For years much of the music associated with Hall was unavailable for performance and the manuscripts could 'be viewed by request only on the premises' of the music library of the New England Conservatory.⁴ Several of these works have only recently become available, often with piano reductions of the accompanying ensembles.

World War I to 1930

Undoubtedly the best-known saxophonist and most prolific composer for the instrument in the years immediately following World War I was Rudy Wiedoeft. Much of his fame was built on the dozens of novelty solos he wrote for the C-melody and alto saxophones. Strongly associated with the ragtime style popular in the 1920s, such technically demanding and cleverly titled works as *Saxarella*, *Saxema*, *Saxophobia* and *Sax-O-Phun* caught the attention of the public. Various effects such as false fingerings, slap-tonguing, and the 'laugh' created an image of the saxophone that still persists. Other popular works by Wiedoeft include a number of florid waltzes such as *Valse Erica* and *Valse Vanité*.

In Europe the saxophone was utilised differently. Three works by German composers and one by an English composer in the 1920s merit mention. The earliest of these, *Façade* by Sir William Walton, dates from 1922; it remains his most famous work. Twenty-one poems by Dame Edith Sitwell are accompanied by a small chamber ensemble consisting mostly of winds. The jazz rhythms capture the spirit of the time and often recall the gaiety of the English dance hall.

Paul Hindemith's Trio, Op. 47, of 1928, is a challenging work for two of the instruments involved. The viola part is a reminder that Hindemith was a world-class violist whose compositions are an important part of the viola literature. The piano score is typically dense and contrapuntal, but the third score, for the now obsolete heckelphone or tenor saxophone in C or B $\flat$, is much less challenging. The piece, however, is a major work by one of the century's great composers and is satisfying both to hear and to perform.

Anton Webern's Quartet for violin, clarinet, tenor saxophone and piano, Op. 22, was conceived as a concerto for violin, clarinet, horn, piano and string orchestra, to be written in the spirit of Bach's Brandenburg Concertos. The Quartet was composed in 1930, and Berg described it as 'a miracle. What amazes me above all is its originality.' Today theorists regard the Quartet as a classically organised masterpiece of formal construction.⁵ Sigfrid Karg-Elert, one of the major organ composers of the twentieth century, also wrote *25 Caprices*, Op. 153a, and an unaccompanied *Atonal Sonata*, Op. 153b, for saxophone in 1929. His interest in the saxophone dates from his service in a regimental army band during World War I. 'Fourteen years ago [1915], the author [Karg-Elert] . . . devoted a great part of his attention and time to the saxophone, a favourite instrument of his. . . .'⁶ Karg-Elert's studies remain pedagogically valuable and his sonata provides an insight into the musical ferment of Germany between the World Wars I and II.

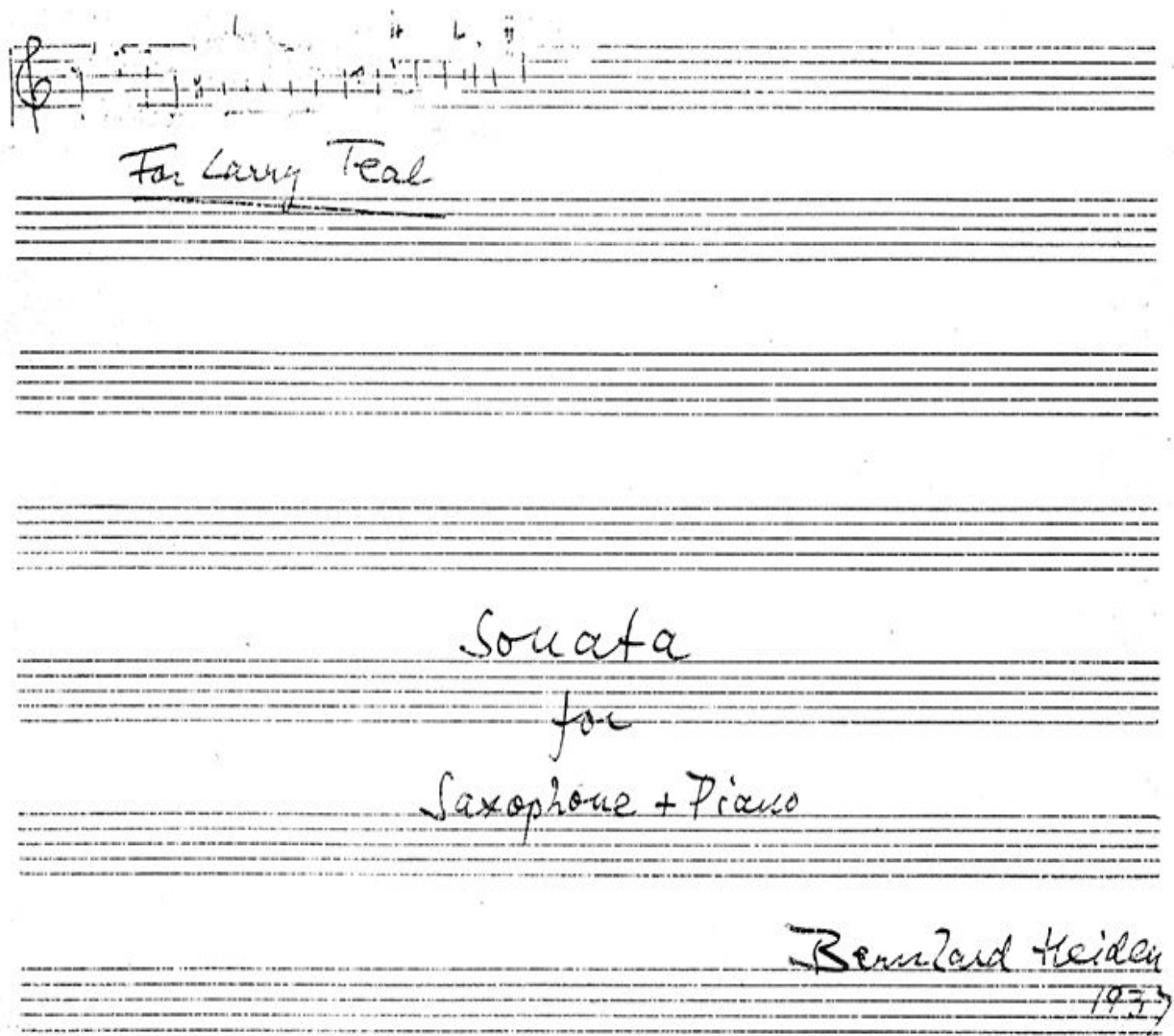


Fig. 4.2 The title page of the Sonata for Saxophone and Piano (1937) by Bernhard Heiden, with dedication to Larry Teal

1931–40

The fourth decade of the twentieth century remains a golden age of serious composition for the saxophone, with lasting contributions by numerous composers. Many of these works were written for Marcel Mule or Sigurd Rascher, but the most important and most frequently performed sonatas for saxophone and piano were composed for two American musicians – Larry Teal and Cecil Leeson.

Bernhard Heiden wrote what has been described as ‘the first substantive sonata for the instrument’⁷ for Teal in 1937. The Sonata, Op. 19, by Paul Creston, written for Leeson in 1939, is regarded as ‘one of the definitive works for saxophone and piano’.⁸ Two works with orchestra were among several written for Rascher – in 1934 the Concerto in E♭, Op. 109, from the Romantic master Alexander Glazunov and the *Concertino da Camera* by Jacques Ibert of 1935, which is ‘often cited as an example of the perfect composition for a solo instrument’.⁹ These four compositions, which form the core of the saxophone repertoire, have received numerous performances, scholarly discussions,¹⁰ and theoretical analyses,¹¹ as well as commentary by their composers and dedicatees.¹² All saxophonists are indebted to the creators of these works and the artists who inspired them.

The 1930s also saw the creation of important works by such significant composers as Paul Hindemith, Frank Martin and Darius Milhaud. Hindemith’s *Konzertstück* for two alto saxophones was written in 1933 but not performed until 1960 and not published until 1970. The first of five *Ballades* for various instruments composed by the Swiss-born Martin is for alto saxophone and orchestra. Written in 1938, the *Ballade* is a powerful work which accelerates and climbs through the registers of the instrument. Like the Hindemith it was composed for Rascher and, again like the *Konzertstück*, for years was not readily available until a piano reduction was published in 1981. The best-known and most popular of the three composers’ works is Milhaud’s *Scaramouche*, Op. 165b. Originally written for Mule for saxophone and orchestra in 1937, the well-known version for two pianos was created by Milhaud the same year.¹³

Two small-scale works for saxophone and piano dedicated to Mule have become repertoire favourites. Eugène Bozza’s *Aria* of 1936, based on Bach’s *Pastorale* for organ BWV 590, is a lyric masterpiece. Originally for saxophone, the *Aria* has appeared for other woodwind instruments, including flute, oboe and bassoon. The *Sonatine Sportive*, Op. 63, written by Alexander Tcherepnin in 1939, is in three brief movements. According to the composer the work attempts to portray in music the surprise elements found in sport. Mule tells us that the *Sonatine* was originally for bassoon and piano and was adapted to the saxophone by the composer.¹⁴

The *Harvard Dictionary of Music* describes an arrangement as ‘the adaptation of a composition for a medium different from that for which it was originally written, so made that the musical substance remains

essentially unchanged'.¹⁵ Arrangements, or transcriptions, have been an important part of music since the early fourteenth century, and have played a significant role in the saxophone's history since its beginning. It was an arrangement by Berlioz of his *Chant sacré* that introduced to the public a sextet of Adolphe Sax's instruments. This first performance, which included a bass saxophone played by its inventor, took place in Paris's Salle Herz on 3 February 1844.¹⁶ Hemke notes Thomas Ryan's performances of transcriptions of music by Schubert, Verdi, Donizetti and Rhode in Boston in the 1860s.¹⁷

Because of the paucity of original recital works, concert artists such as Leeson, Mule and Rascher adapted music of earlier periods to the saxophone. It is said that it was Rascher's performances of Bach that first interested composers such as Edmund von Borck to write concertos for him. In addition, Mule found in the music of the Baroque, Classical and early Romantic periods excellent pedagogical materials for the teaching of various historical styles.

Some of the earliest and most successful transcriptions by Leeson were of music by Bach, Kreisler and Schubert. Among Mule's more than a hundred *Pièces célèbres* are short works by Gluck, Lully and Mendelssohn as well as complete sonatas by Bach and Handel; many of these are still available to students and performers. Several arrangements by Rascher remain in print, ranging from short teaching pieces to concert-length works.

Saxophonists have long enriched their programmes with music of different periods. This trend will undoubtedly continue as music of the late Romantic and early twentieth century eras enters the public domain. A recent phenomenon is the use of music originally for other media which is transposed at sight by the performer rather than rewritten in the appropriate key; this is especially true of flute and oboe works performed on soprano saxophone.

1941–50

The decade of the 1940s is, in many ways, similar to the 1930s; among the rapidly growing repertoire are two important concertos – one written for Leeson and one for Rascher – and several works composed for Mule. Although undoubtedly slowed by the Second World War, interest in the classical saxophone continued in France and the United States. The last and

longest of the compositions which resulted from Paul Creston's collaboration with Cecil Leeson is the Concerto, Op. 26, of 1941. The work is characteristic of the best of Creston's music – long melodies, rich harmonies, flamboyant rhythms and a virtuoso solo score – and amply demonstrates his declaration that 'the saxophone is the perfect solo instrument'.¹⁸

Ingolf Dahl's Concerto of 1949 for Rascher is a landmark in the repertoire of solo instruments with wind accompaniment, and is one of the earliest works to fully utilise the potential of the complete symphonic band. A dearth of performances caused by the formidable difficulties of both the solo and the accompanying parts prompted Dahl to revise the Concerto in 1953. Dahl is said to have made a second unacknowledged revision in 1959 which reduced the length of the Concerto by approximately a quarter, and this is the version which has been published.¹⁹ A protégé of Stravinsky, Dahl also conducted the Collegium Musicum at the University of Southern California where he was a faculty member. The latter influence can be found in the first two movements – Recitative and Adagio (Passacaglia) – and his close association with Stravinsky can be heard in the texture, diatonicism and virtuosity of all three movements.

Another work for the same instrumentation as Dahl's Concerto, but of a decidedly more popular flavour, is the *Introduction and Samba* composed for Rascher in 1950 by Maurice Whitney. The work exploits the saxophone's agility and its upper register while the band's role is considerably less demanding. It has recently been reprinted with the original saxophone part and a piano reduction.

Four works inspired by Mule have entered the repertoire from this decade. Pierre Lantier's brief and bittersweet *Sicilienne* of 1943 is a melodic gem that captures Mule's singing approach to the saxophone. The *Improvisation* and *Caprice* of Eugène Bozza are the sixth and seventh of his *Etudes caprices*, Op. 60, written in 1944. The *Caprice* is a homage to Mule's remarkable technical facility, as is another difficult but idiomatic work for solo saxophone, the *Caprice en forme de valse*, written in 1950 by Paul Bonneau. Bonneau had studied the saxophone with Mule 'for a brief period, primarily so that he would be proficient on a band instrument when he entered military service. A talented man, he became a respectable saxophonist in about six months.'²⁰

Heitor Villa-Lobos' *Fantasia*, Op. 630, of 1948 is undoubtedly the most important work for the soprano instrument. Scored for soprano saxophone, three horns and strings, the *Fantasia* contains many of the Brazilian composer's most famous characteristics – vigorous native rhythms, long languid melodies and Bachian counterpoint. Although the work is dedicated to Mule, he never performed it.²¹ Rousseau tells us that when he produced the first and definitive recording in 1971 there was no evidence that the orchestral parts had ever been played.²²

1951–60

The growth in the saxophone repertoire, begun in the 1930s and slowed by the Second World War, regained its momentum after the conflict and accelerated through the next two decades. Several of the works composed during the period have demonstrated their worth and have remained in the repertoire. More French contributions appeared, with Jeanine Rueff's *Chanson et passepied* of 1951 among the first of the decade. This brief and charming work uses the same material in each of its two sections, closing with a brilliant syncopated flourish. More substantial compositions for Mule include the *Tableaux de Provence* by another of his colleagues at the Paris Conservatoire, Paule Maurice, wife of Pierre Lantier. The suite, in five colourful movements, depicts the area in the south-east of France where the Lantier and Mule families spent several summers and to where Mule retired. Written during the years 1954–9, the reduction of the orchestral score is unusually idiomatic to the piano. During Mule's years at the Conservatoire twenty-five compositions were written for the Conservatoire's annual contest. Perhaps the best known of these compositions dates from 1956: the *Prélude, cadence et finale* of Alfred Desenclos; its cadenza is a 'must' for all serious saxophonists. This virtuoso work requires the refined approach and complete command of the instrument which exemplify Mule's students.

An outstanding product of Mule's classes is Jean-Marie Londeix, for whom Pierre-Max Dubois wrote a Concerto in 1959. A remarkably prolific composer, Dubois has written more than fifty works for the saxophone in various settings, ranging from solo saxophone to ensembles of eleven players. The Concerto is unusual because of its slow introduction and lengthy opening cadenza and is notable for its kaleidoscopic shifts of tonality.

The middle movement of Warren Benson's Concertino of 1955, the *Aeolian Song*, was written for Rascher and requires a flexible and assured control of the altissimo register. Also composed for Rascher was Karel Husa's *Elégie et rondeau* of 1960; it is in one movement, with the *élégie* leading directly into the *rondeau*. In the *élégie*, which is drawn from an earlier work written in 1957 for solo piano, Husa sought to display 'the legato, beautiful expressive sound of the saxophone'. The contrasting *rondeau* starts softly and becomes progressively stronger to capitalise on the 'incredible power' of the instrument.²³

1961–70

The repertoire continued to increase in quantity and quality as new artists continued to appear and as saxophone teaching positions at major schools of music were created. In 1967, Eugene Rousseau, who had studied with Mule in Paris, received *Quattro Lirich brevi*, Op. 61, from his colleague at Indiana University, the Chilean-born Juan Orrego-Salas. Leslie Bassett composed his *Music for Saxophone and Piano* in 1968 for Donald Sinta; Sinta, a student of Teal at the University of Michigan, would later succeed Teal at that school.

Composers also continued to write for already established performers such as Mule and Rascher. Ida Gotkovsky's brilliant Concerto was written for Mule in 1966 and is an outstanding example of the saxophone contest pieces created at the Paris Conservatoire. Henry Cowell wrote his *Air and Scherzo* in 1961 as another demonstration of Rascher's mastery of the altissimo register. In an interesting reversal of expectations, the 'gay' minor scherzo contains a 'sad' trio in the parallel major key.

Rascher also gave the first performance of what many regard as the most important composition for saxophone in the second half of the twentieth century.



Some sketches
from the
Sketchbook
concerts
to Tom Wiley
5-11-82
Parchment

May 1982

Fig. 4.3 Sketches from the Concerto for Alto Saxophone and Concert Band (1967) by Karel Husa

The impetus for the Concerto for Alto Saxophone and Concert Band of 1967 by Karel Husa originated with Donald Sinta. Husa and Sinta were both residents of Ithaca, New York. Sinta, however, took a new teaching position elsewhere and Rascher, who was already well known to Husa, was selected as the soloist for the first performance. By 1976 the Concerto was already considered ‘a classic in the literature of the saxophone’.²⁴ The three-movement work consists of a heroic, recitative-like Prologue; an intensely rhythmic Ostinato; and an Epilogue which begins from and ends with *niente* (nothing).²⁵

The end of the decade saw the first of the World Saxophone Congresses, assembling performers, teachers and students from around the world. Beginning with the first Congress in 1969, premières of new work have been an important feature at each gathering. The first new composition to be heard was by Bernhard Heiden, whose Sonata has long been a mainstay of the repertoire; his *Solo* is dedicated to his colleague Eugene Rousseau and to the first Congress. The second Congress, held in 1970, heard two important new sonatas: Robert Muczynski’s Op. 29, written for Trent Kynaston, is very American in its melodies, harmonies and rhythms; whilst the Russian composer Edison Denisov used complex metres and quarter-tones in his sonata for Jean-Marie Londeix; both sonatas unmistakably share the influence of jazz.

The most recent decades

At the beginning of the twenty-first century, the saxophone repertoire continues to receive significant contributions. The instrument will, of course, never have original music by Bach, Mozart or Schubert, but the heritage of compositions written since the instrument’s creation around 1840 is the equal of any other wind instrument in the past 150 years. It may yet be too early to determine which works of the most recent decades will establish themselves as permanent members of the repertoire. Several compositions, however, seem to have the musical worth and performer interest to join the works already mentioned.

Ross Lee Finney’s Concerto, written in 1974 to commemorate the retirement of Larry Teal from the University of Michigan, is both substantive and compelling. John Anthony Lennon’s atmospheric *Distances Within Me*,

first performed at the 1979 World Saxophone Congress, employs a contemporary harmonic language to speak persuasively to contemporary audiences. Robert Muczynski's Concerto, Op. 41 (1981), is a noteworthy heir to his highly successful Sonata, and concertinos written by Paul Harvey (1974) and Walter Hartley (1978) reflect the renewed interest in the tenor saxophone generated by James Houlik. Several of the numerous and complex works by the French composer Christian Lauba have attracted much attention, which may well be sustained.

In recognition of the substantial fees commanded by renowned composers, several saxophonists have occasionally combined resources to attract finances for major commissions. Among the results are sonatas from William Albright, William Bolcom and David Diamond in 1984; in 1987, Morton Subotnick's *In Two Worlds* for alto saxophone, computer and orchestra;²⁶ and in 1988 the *Partita*, Op. 100, for alto saxophone, violin, violoncello and piano by Juan Orrego-Salas.²⁷ Each work was funded by the National Endowment for the Arts.

For Eugene Rousseau

JINDŘICH FELD

SONATA

for Alto Saxophone and Piano

(1989 - 90)

Durata cca 21 min.

Fig. 4.4 The title page of the Sonata for Saxophone and Piano (1990) by Jindřich Feld, with dedication to Eugene Rousseau

The compositions of the Czech Jindřich Feld hold considerable promise of establishing themselves as notable members of the repertoire. Feld's music contains both forceful melodic lines and sophisticated rhythmic structures. His Concerto of 1980 – yet another work first performed at a World Saxophone Congress – and his Sonata of 1990 present the most contemporary compositional techniques in an accessible manner that should maintain his music in the twenty-first century.

Più mosso (♩ = 134)

Handwritten musical score for a piece titled "Più mosso" with a tempo marking of $\text{♩} = 134$. The score is written on ten staves, with the first four staves grouped by a brace on the left. The notation includes various musical symbols such as notes, rests, and dynamic markings. The key signature has one flat (B-flat). The time signature is 16/16. The score includes several dynamic markings: "p" (piano), "poco a poco" (poco a poco), "crescendo", "sforzando", "pp" (pianissimo), and "mf" (mezzo-forte). There are also markings for "Red." (Reduction) and "mf" (mezzo-forte). The score is numbered 1 through 15 at the end of each staff. The notation is handwritten and includes many accidentals and slurs.

Fig. 4.5 Manuscript of Feld's Sonata, as used at the first performance

Both of the Feld pieces were written for Eugene Rousseau, who has suggested an aesthetic by which the saxophone's future repertoire may be determined:

If the saxophone has a future as a classical instrument, it will be because of its melodic use and not because of *avant-garde* pieces, great though they may be. The basic human spirit responds emotionally to melody. With the other music we might say the music is 'interesting', or that we were 'on the edge of our seats', but we're not sure if we want to hear that piece again or not. Or maybe we do hear it again and then we're *sure* we don't want to hear it any more, or maybe we want to hear it many times. Regardless of the final decision, the music still doesn't evoke the same response.²⁸

Adolphe Sax understood in the 1850s that the saxophone, in order to be sustained, must have a repertoire worthy of the instrument and its audiences. A century-and-a-half later there exists a body of literature which has established the saxophone as a significant concert instrument, while the number of pre-eminent composers of high merit and international renown who have written for the instrument has grown conspicuously. They 'are making the saxophone an instrument capable of answering the highest musical demands of the time [and] have finally made the instrument indispensable to "classical" music and justify the involvement of our best musicians in the rendering of this concert music'.²⁹